

test drive ■ tv tuner

Don't you wish life had a rewind or instant replay function? Have you ever thought of killing your boss, burning your company, divorcing your significant other, sending your kids to boarding school, moving out from home, or just becoming a recluse? All because you missed that one program on TV that you'd waited forever to see, and something more important came up? It happens to all of us, TV addicts or not—be it that must-see episode of *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*, *Jassi Jaise Koi Nahi*, or a cricket match. But who says that's the way life has to be?

Enter, Stage Right, TV tuner cards and PVR (Personal Video Recording) software; their role used to be played by the now outdated VCR. These gadgets make sure you never miss another programme ever again—barring power failures, hurricanes, fires and acts of divinity, of course. All you need is a decent computer setup, a cable connection and decent speakers, and you can turn your PC

into a media centre. Think of it as buying a second TV for the family, for as little as Rs 1,700.

however, denied any involvement, stating that

As always, there are so many options. Though brands such as Hauppauge are still not available, others do the job to satisfaction. Some local brands that only let you watch TV on your monitor are available, but as usual, *yeh dil maange more*. So, we decided to look for cards that do more than just display a few channels on your PC monitor. We looked for cards that let you capture video, in real time; cards that can capture MPEG-2 on the fly; PVR software that's easy to set up, and even easier to use; software that can convert between file formats later, and anything more on the offer.

The latest breed of cards offer advanced features such as time shifting, MPEG-2 capture, FM radio, NICAM stereo capture, and more. They're connected via a PCI or USB interface, and have impressive capabilities. How impressive? Read on to find out.



TV TUNER

Though some TV tuner cards offer more than others, it doesn't necessarily make them better. We got 10 cards for our comparison from all the major players in the market including Pinnacle, PixelView, Mercury, Compro and a new entrant—Aviosys.

Package contents

Package contents are important when buying a TV tuner card. The bundled software should include Personal Video Recording (PVR) software; tried and tested utilities such as WinDVR and Cyberlink PowerVCR are the most commonly bundled software. Pinnacle stuck to their proprietary software, and bundled only the trial version of Studio 7 with both, the PCTV Plus and PCTV PRO. A toned-down version of the expensive Studio 7 software would have definitely been welcome; they offered all the necessary wires and a remote control. Pinnacle only bundled a quick start guide in the form of documentation—the manual is on the CD. The remote is handy and works well.

Aviosys only provided a quick start guide, unlike the Pixelview TV cards which came with an extensive manual and a

Suitable Alternatives

Instead of spending thousands of rupees on a TV, you can buy a TV tuner card and watch TV on your computer. If you don't want to capture content, and only want to watch TV, you can buy a set-top-box. These boxes do not connect to your PC, just to your monitor. They can't capture content, but instead, let you use your monitor as a full-fledged TV. Though some manufacturers sent a few of these in to be tested, we didn't include them in our test—they just don't fit into the PVR category. But in case you are looking, there are cheaper no-frills alternatives for watching TV on your monitor.

Compro VideoMate TV Gold Plus



A winning package

Definitely the best of the lot, this is the only card that had markings on the back panel of the Printed Circuit Board (PCB) to indicate what goes where while inserting it. The faulty drivers led to some hiccups in its configuration. The channels were not detected properly, and ran into each other with jumbled characters appearing onscreen. However, all was fine after we installed the patch downloaded from www.comprousa.com. This was tedious, but definitely worth it.

The bundled software lets you write directly to DVDs. The bundled application is intuitive, easy to use and has a satchel of features. The feature to enhance the picture quality is very natty, and comes in handy while capturing content. You can take snapshots of various channels, but these look icky on a 14-inch screen. The channels are also not updated fast enough. Scheduled recording brings your system out of Standby or Hibernate mode when it's time to record. It also has an option to turn off the system after completing the job. This is useful for late-night recordings. Good software bundled with cool features made this card our performance winner.

